Unit 2

Rhythm Against Rhythm

New: Two against three, three against four, duplets, quintuplets and septuplets, hemiola

Until now both hands have shared one way of dividing the beat: both in eighths, or both in triplets. In much Romantic and Impressionist music the hands divide the beat differently: the right hand plays three notes while the left plays two, or the tune floats in free groups of five or seven over a steady accompaniment. This unit teaches you to feel two rhythms at once.

The secret is to keep one hand completely steady (usually the accompaniment) and let the other fit around it. Practise the combinations slowly with the rhymes below until they are automatic; then read the exercises at the speed shown.

What is new

Two against three

Three triplet eighths in one hand, two eighths in the other: both hands play together on the beat; the second eighth comes exactly between the 2nd and 3rd triplet notes. Say "nice cup of tea": "nice" together, "cup" triplet, "of" eighth, "tea" triplet.

Three against four

Triplet eighths in one hand, sixteenths in the other: together on the beat, then the notes interlock. Say "pass the golden butter": "pass" together, then sixteenth, triplet, sixteenth, triplet, sixteenth.

Duplets

In 6/8 the beat is a dotted quarter, normally three eighths. A duplet (marked 2) fits two equal notes into the beat: each one lasts one and a half eighths. The left hand's three eighths go on underneath: it is two against three again.

Runs of 5, 6 and 7

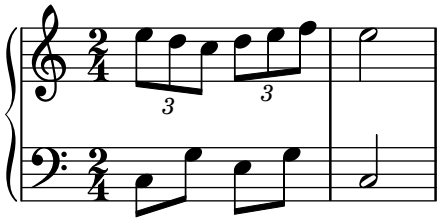
A group of 5, 6 or 7 small notes marked with its number fills one beat. Do not count them: start the run on the beat, aim for the note after it, and arrive on time. The left hand keeps the beat.

Hemiola

In 3/4, two bars can suddenly move in half notes: three half notes across the two bars, the middle one tied over the bar line. The music sounds as if it were in 3/2 for a moment. Accents show it; keep counting 1-2-3 and feel the slower beat on top.

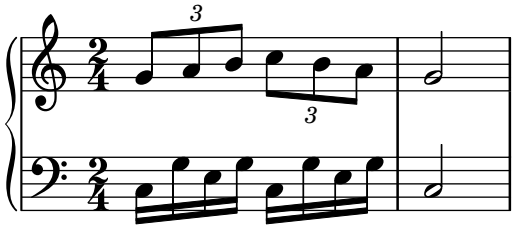
Two against three

Right hand triplets, left hand eighths. Both hands play on each beat; the left hand's second eighth falls exactly between the second and third notes of the triplet.



Three against four

Triplet eighths against sixteenths: together on the beat, then sixteenth, triplet, sixteenth, triplet, sixteenth ("pass the golden butter").



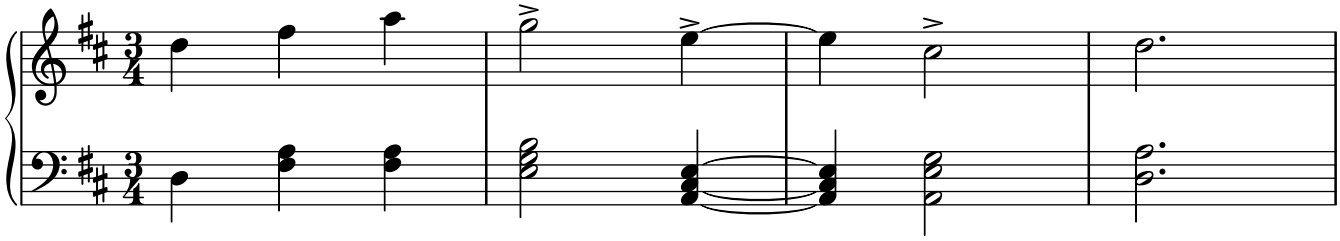
A duplet in 6/8, and a run of five

Bar 1: the duplet (two notes in the time of three eighths) against the left hand's eighths. Bar 2: five notes fill the first beat and lead into the half note.



A hemiola

Bars 2-3 move in three half notes, the middle one tied over the bar line. Keep counting three beats in a bar, and let the accents carry the slower pulse.



Reading tips

1. Practise each new combination with one hand tapping and the other clapping before you read it.
2. Keep the accompaniment perfectly even; fit the other hand around it.
3. Look at where the two hands play together: those points are your anchors.
4. In a run, look at the note after the run first: that is where you must arrive, on the beat.
5. In a hemiola, do not change your counting: feel the half notes against it.

Part A: Two against three ♩= 60

Two against three. In half of the exercises the right hand has the tune in eighths over the left hand's triplets; in the other half the left hand has the tune and the right hand plays the triplets.

☐ **2.1**



☐ **2.2**



☐ **2.3**



☐ **2.4**



☐ **2.5**



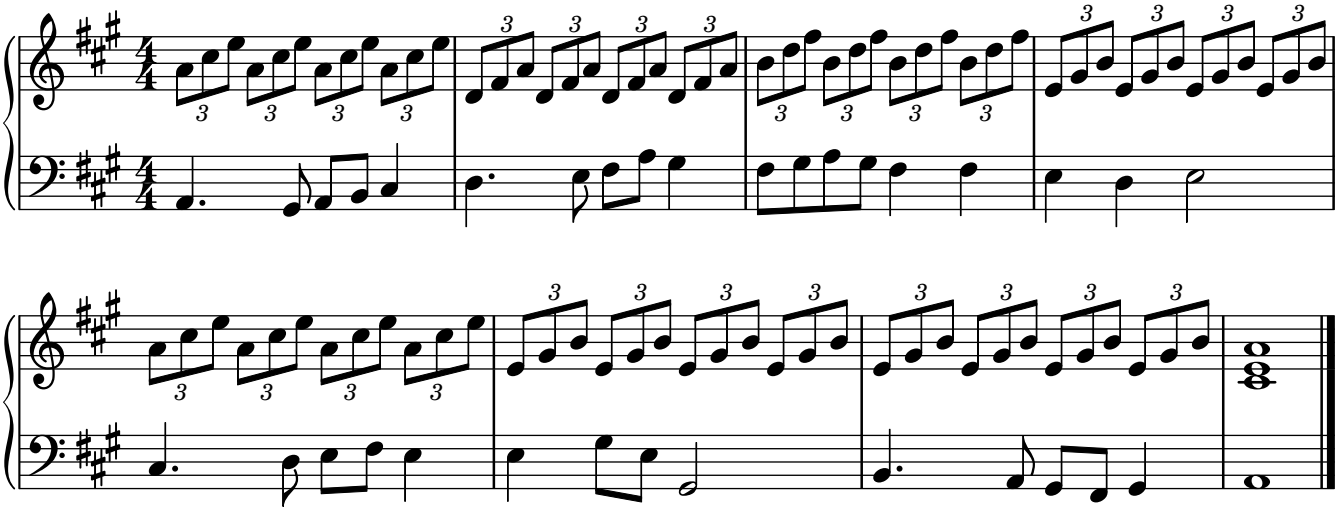
☐ **2.6**



☐ **2.7**



☐ **2.8**



Part B: Duplets, and three against four ♩. = 56

Duplets in 6/8 (two notes in a dotted-quarter beat) over the left hand's eighths, alternating with 2/4 exercises in which right-hand triplets meet left-hand sixteenths (three against four).

☐ **2.9**



☐ **2.10** ♩ = 56



☐ **2.11**



2.12 ♩ = 56



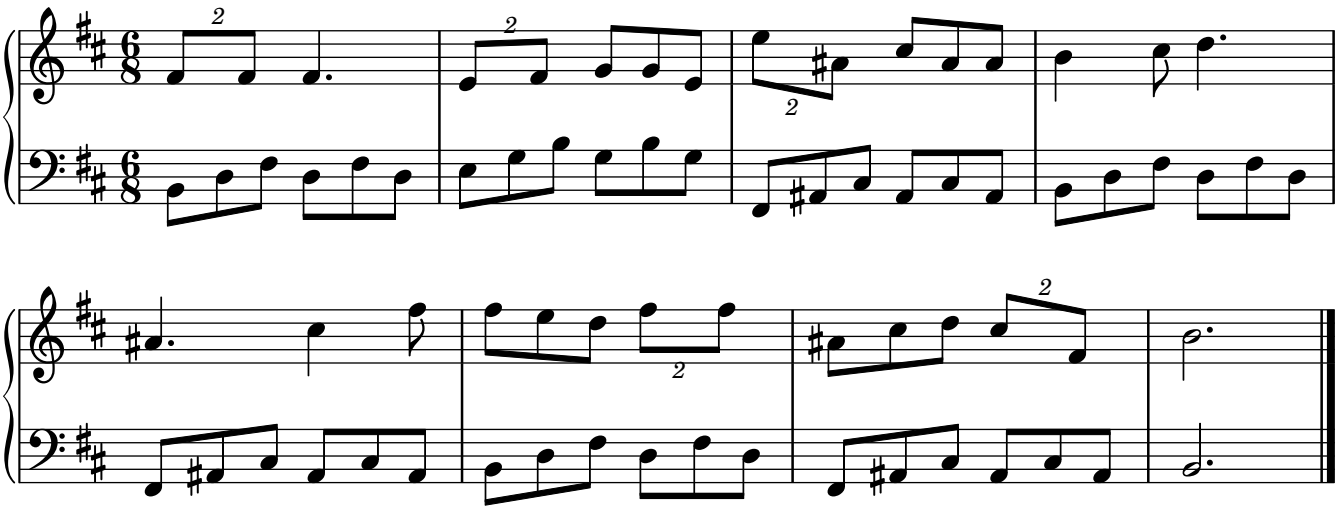
2.13



2.14 ♩ = 56



2.15



2.16 ♩ = 56



Part C: Runs of 5, 6 and 7 notes, and hemiolas ♩= 60

Runs of 5, 6 or 7 notes (two in each exercise), alternating with 3/4 waltzes that end with a hemiola in bars 6-7.

☐ **2.17**



☐ **2.18** ♩= 96



☐ **2.19**



2.20 ♩ = 96



2.21



2.22 ♩ = 96



2.23



2.24 ♩ = 96



Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Arabesque No. 1 ♩ = 63

Claude Debussy (1888-91), Arabesque No. 1, L. 66 - bars 6-12, with a closing chord

Two against three all through: the right hand's triplets float over the left hand's even eighths. Keep the left hand quiet and perfectly steady; in bars 5-7 the right hand mixes triplets with plain eighths. Four sharps: E major. Debussy's piece goes on; the excerpt closes on an E major chord. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1777 (public domain).



Nocturne in E-flat ♩. = 44

Frederic Chopin (1830-32), Nocturne Op. 9 No. 2 - the first phrase

12/8: four beats of three eighths. The left hand keeps an even bass-and-chord pattern of eighths while the tune sings freely above it. In bar 2 the four quick notes are Chopin's turn written out (D-flat, C, B-natural, C, all in the time of one eighth); in bar 4 the sixteenths make two notes against each eighth of the left hand. Count four slow beats, not twelve. The excerpt ends with the first phrase. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 1590 (Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 3.0).



Solace ♩= 60

Scott Joplin (1909), Solace: A Mexican Serenade - the first strain

A habanera: the left hand plays a dotted eighth, a sixteenth and two eighths in every bar, while the right hand's sixteenths are tied over the middle of the bar. The two rhythms never coincide after the first note: keep the left hand's pattern steady and fit the right hand's ties against it. Joplin marks it "very slow march time". Joplin writes each bass note held under the chord (for the pedal); here it is printed as the eighth the hand actually plays. Source: Mutopia Project no. 482 (public domain).



Hemiola Waltz ♩ = 104

Original, written for this book

A waltz with two hemiolas. In bars 7-8 and 13-14 the music moves in three half notes across two bars (the accents show them; the middle one is tied over the bar line): the first time it stops on A, the dominant, the second time it leads home to D. Keep counting three in a bar and let the half notes sound broad and slow.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 3?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if the hands keep their own rhythms: the triplets stay even against the eighths, the duplets are equal, and every run arrives on the beat.
- Pass if you can play the Hemiola Waltz at sight and the Arabesque excerpt after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 3.